

Herald



Herald — Missing Environment Variables (BLOCKER)

Field	Value
Document	Operator action — provide MTPROTO credentials
Created	2026-05-28
Status	BLOCKING Wave 8 Track B (§11.4.98 full-automation compliance)
Blocks	TestSubscribe_LiveBotAPI rewrite, tests/test_wave6_live_loop.sh rewrite, Wave 6.5 lifecycle scenarios — all currently NON-COMPLIANT per §11.4.98
Authority	HelixConstitution §11.4.98 + Herald §108.m (HelixConstitution commit 6828ff2, Herald commit bbff03c8)
Audit anchor	docs/qa/HRD-LIVE-20260528T082128Z/README.md
Resolution path	Populate 3 required + 1 optional HERALD_MTPROTO_* variables in .env; reply "done"

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⚠ **CRITICAL — read this BEFORE starting Step 1**

This setup uses an **unofficial Telegram client** (gotd/td library, MTProto layer). Per Telegram's own [official documentation](#) and the gotd/td maintainer guidance:

"Due to excessive abuse of the Telegram API, **all accounts that sign up or log in using unofficial Telegram clients are automatically put under observation** to avoid violations of the Terms of Service."

Three hard rules you MUST follow to avoid a permanent account ban:

1. **EMAIL** `recover@telegram.org` **BEFORE or AT first login** — explain in plain words what the QA account will do. Suggested template:

To: `recover@telegram.org`

Subject: `Userbot purpose declaration – Herald automation testing`

`Hello Telegram team,`

`I'm setting up a userbot via the MTProto API (using the gotd/td Go lib for the Herald open-source project (https://github.com/vasic-digital/Herald))`

`The userbot will:`

- `- Send 3-10 messages per test run to a single group I own (chat_id -4946584787 "ATMOSphere Development") – entirely automated testing of an internal bot's behaviour`
- `- Receive replies from that internal bot (@atmosphere_worker_bot)`
- `- Run ~5-20 test campaigns per day in CI`
- `- Never send messages to users outside this group`
- `- Never flood, spam, scrape, fake subscribers, or fake view counts`
- `- Use the gotd/contrib rate-limit + flood-wait middlewares`

`Phone: <YOUR E.164 PHONE>`

`App: "Herald" (api_id will be assigned by my.telegram.org/apps)`

`Please flag this account as a known QA-automation userbot so the anti-abuse system does not put it under suspicion.`

`Thank you,
<your name>`

Send this email **FIRST**. It takes Telegram ~0-3 days to acknowledge. Do not wait — proceed with Steps 1-5 in parallel, but the email must go **BEFORE** you make heavy use of the userbot.

2. **DO NOT use a VoIP / Google Voice / Twilio / TextNow / virtual number.** Earlier versions of this guide listed VoIP as "option (c)". That guidance was wrong. Telegram's anti-abuse system flags VoIP numbers aggressively and bans them at the slightest provocation. **Use only:**

- **Option (a)** — your personal Telegram account (proven number, has trust history). Fastest path. Recommended for first-cycle proof.
- **Option (b)** — a dedicated SIM (eSIM is fine). Best long-term.

3. **One phone = ONE app_id, FOREVER.** Per Telegram's official docs: "For the moment each number can only have one api_id connected to it." If the phone you choose already has an app at my.telegram.org/apps from a previous project, **you MUST reuse it** — there is no way to create a second one for the same phone. The app_id + app_hash are also **non-regenerable** — if you lose them, you lose them forever (revoke + recreate is possible only for accounts that have NEVER had an app, which doesn't apply once you've created one).

Additional anti-ban hygiene (composes with §11.4.10 / §11.4.98):

- Use the harness **PASSIVELY** — receive more than send.
- Rate-limit via github.com/gotd/contrib/middleware/ratelimit (already vendored in submodules/gotd-td).
- Honor FLOOD_WAIT_<N> responses via github.com/gotd/contrib/middleware/floodwait (also vendored).
- Never share HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_HASH or the session file. Both are sufficient to impersonate the account.

If your account gets banned despite all this, email recover@telegram.org from the same address explaining the userbot's purpose. Bans by the automated system can be reversed by a human reviewer when the use case is clearly legitimate.

1. Why this blocker exists

Universal Constitution §11.4.98 **Full-Automation Anti-Bluff Mandate** (anchored 2026-05-28 by your verbatim instruction):

"Make sure we have full automation testing of all scenarios with real bot, main group and users without any manual intervention or contribution of real user! Everything **MUST BE** fully automatic and autonomous! These tests **MUST BE** able to rerun endless times when needed! [...] No bluff is allowed!"

Herald has **three live tests** that currently require you to hand-send a Telegram message during their execution — making them §11.4 PASS-bluffs at the automation layer (cannot run in CI, cannot validate regressions between manual runs, human dependency masks drift):

Test	Manual action currently required
TestSubscribe_LiveBotAPI	Operator hand-sends a message during a 60s window
tests/ test_wave6_live_loop.sh	Operator hand-sends a message; waits for bot reply
Wave 6.5 lifecycle scenarios	Operator hand-sends each scenario's stimulus

The fix is to drive these tests from a **Telegram user account** (not a bot) via the **MTPROTO protocol** — the same wire protocol Telegram apps use. **Why not a second bot?** Empirically verified 2026-05-28: @pherald_qa_bot (id 8971749017) sent message_id=18 to group -4946584787 (ATMOSphere Development); the worker bot @atmosphere_worker_bot observed **0 updates**. Telegram's privacy boundary is structural: bots cannot see other bots' messages in non-DM contexts. MTPROTO user-impersonation is the only autonomous path.

The harness lives in `qaherald/internal/mtpROTO/` (vendored github.com/gotd/td). Once you provide credentials and complete the one-time login (the §11.4.98(B) permitted

exception — configuration, not test driving), **every subsequent test run is fully autonomous**, re-runnable endlessly with no human action.

2. What's already in .env

Audited 2026-05-28 (presence-only, no values echoed):

Variable	Status
HERALD_PROJECT_NAME	✓ Set
HERALD_TGRAM_BOT_TOKEN	✓ Set (@atmosphere_worker_bot, id 8823384001)
HERALD_TGRAM_CHAT_ID	✓ Set (-4946584787, "ATMOSphere Development" group)
HERALD_QA_BOT_TOKEN	✓ Set (@pherald_qa_bot, id 8971749017) — but cannot drive worker bot (bot-to-bot wall, see §1)
HERALD_OPERATOR_IDS	✓ Set
HERALD_CLAUDE_BIN	✓ Set (/Users/milosvasic/.local/bin/claude, v2.1.153)
HERALD_CLAUDE_PROJECT_NAME	✓ Set (Herald)
HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_ID	✗ MISSING — required
HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_HASH	✗ MISSING — required
HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE	✗ MISSING — required
HERALD_MTPROTO_PASSWORD	✗ MISSING — required ONLY if 2FA enabled

3. What you must provide

Four variables, one optional. Add to your existing .env (it's git-ignored at .gitignore:28):

```
# §11.4.98 MTPROTO user-account harness (Wave 8 Track B)
HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_ID=<integer, 5-8 digits, from my.telegram.org/
apps>
HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_HASH=<32-char hex string, from
my.telegram.org/apps>
HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE=<E.164 phone of QA user account, e.g.
+12025551234>
HERALD_MTPROTO_PASSWORD=<only if 2FA enabled on the account;
otherwise leave blank>
```

Where each value comes from:

Variable	What it is	How to get
HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_ID	App api_id (integer)	https://my.telegram.org/apps — see Step 1 below
HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_HASH	App api_hash (32-char hex)	Same page — see Step 1
HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE	Phone in E.164 format	

Variable	What it is (+countrycode + number, no spaces / dashes)	How to get YOUR phone (the Telegram user account that will drive QA tests). See Step 2 for account-choice trade-offs. Set in Telegram → Settings → Privacy & Security → Two-Step Verification (only if you've enabled 2FA on the account in HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE)
HERALD_MTPROTO_PASSWORD	Cloud 2FA password	

4. Step 1 — Create the Telegram app at my.telegram.org

Estimated time: 5 minutes (one-time only).

1. **Open browser** to <https://my.telegram.org/auth>.
2. **Enter the QA-driver phone** in E.164 format (e.g. +12025551234).
 - This must be the same number you'll put in HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE later.
 - It **MUST** be a Telegram **user account**, not a bot.
3. **Telegram sends a login code** to that phone's Telegram app (in-app notification, not SMS).
4. **Enter the code** at my.telegram.org/auth.
5. **You're now logged in** to Telegram's developer dashboard. Navigate to <https://my.telegram.org/apps>.
6. **First-time:** click "**Create new application**". Fill in (values updated 2026-05-28 after operator-reported Incorrect app name validation error):

Field	Value to enter	Telegram's hidden constraint
App title	Herald OR HeraldQA OR Herald Test Harness (try one; if "Incorrect app name" appears, try the next)	3-32 chars; letters + digits + spaces ONLY; NO 2-letter all-caps tokens like "QA"; NO digits-only words. Telegram rejects names that look like abbreviations / acronyms. The all-caps "QA" alone triggers Incorrect app name. Use a full word OR squish into camelCase (HeraldQA) so Telegram's parser doesn't see a bare acronym.
Short name	herald_qa_<random> (e.g. herald_qa_5kx9)	5-32 chars; alphanumeric + underscore ONLY; NO spaces; NO leading digit; GLOBALLY UNIQUE across all Telegram apps. "GLOBALLY UNIQUE" is the killer: someone else might already have herald_qa. Always append a random 4-char suffix on the FIRST attempt.
URL	https://herald.local (or any valid http(s)://... URL — the field is NOT optional on the	Must start with http:// or https:// — Telegram rejects bare domains. Can be a fake/placeholder

Field	Value to enter	Telegram's hidden constraint
	validation step despite earlier guidance)	URL — Telegram only validates the SHAPE, not that the URL resolves.
Platform	Desktop (from dropdown — Other is rejected by some Telegram form versions)	Pick Desktop if Other errors out. Either works for our use case — the "Platform" field is metadata only, doesn't gate any API behaviour.
Description	Herald automation harness for closed-loop testing.	Plain ASCII; the § symbol in earlier versions of this guide tripped some Telegram form validators. Keep under 200 chars. Avoid abbreviations (QA, CI, CD) — pair them with full-word context or drop them.

⚠️ **KNOWN ISSUE (operator-reported 2026-05-28): "Incorrect app name"**

This error is returned when the **App title** contains a bare acronym, abbreviation, or otherwise looks "non-app-like" to Telegram's classifier. Confirmed-rejected titles:

- ❌ Herald QA (the QA is a bare 2-letter all-caps token — Telegram's classifier flags it as not-a-real-name)
- ❌ Herald QA 2026 (same — the date doesn't rescue it)
- ❌ pherald (lowercase + leading letter that looks like a prefix)
- ❌ QA (too short + all-caps)

Confirmed-accepted titles (try in this order):

- ✅ Herald (simplest; works almost always)
- ✅ HeraldQA (camelCase squish — Telegram parses as a single word)
- ✅ Herald Test Harness (full English words)
- ✅ Herald Tools (full English words)
- ✅ Herald Lab (full English words)

If Telegram still rejects all of the above with `Incorrect app name`, your account may be rate-limited or flagged — wait 1 hour and try again with a different combination.

7. Click "Create application".

8. Telegram now displays two values on the page:

- App api_id — small integer (5-8 digits). → This is your `HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_ID`.
- App api_hash — 32-character lowercase hex string. → This is your `HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_HASH`.

9. ⚠️ **COPY BOTH VALUES IMMEDIATELY.** Telegram does NOT let you re-display the api_hash after you navigate away. If you lose it, you must revoke the app + create a new one (which invalidates any existing sessions).

If you got a form-validation error on your first attempt (operator-reported 2026-05-28):

The most common cause is the `short_name` field. Telegram requires:

1. **5-32 characters** (your previous attempt may have been too short).
2. **Alphanumeric + underscore ONLY** — no -, no ., no spaces.

3. **No leading digit** — `5herald_qa` fails; `herald_qa_5kx9` is fine.
4. **GLOBALLY UNIQUE across ALL Telegram apps** — `herald_qa` may already be taken by someone else. Always append a random suffix on the first attempt.

Recommended `short_name` values to try (in order):

- `herald_qa_$(openssl rand -hex 2)` — generate via shell: produces something like `herald_qa_5kx9`
- `herald_qa_<your-username>` — e.g. `herald_qa_milos`
- `herald_qa_<YYYYMMDD>` — e.g. `herald_qa_20260528`
- `herald_qa_test_<NNN>` — e.g. `herald_qa_test_001`

Other form-validation gotchas:

- **URL field is NOT actually optional** despite Telegram's UI sometimes labelling it so. Use `https://herald.local` or `https://github.com/vasic-digital/Herald` — any valid `http(s)://` URL passes. Bare strings like `github.com/vasic-digital/Herald` (no scheme) are rejected.
- **Platform field:** Other works on most Telegram versions but some form deployments reject it; **fall back to Desktop** if Other errors.
- **Description with non-ASCII characters** (`$`, `→`, em-dash, etc.) is rejected by some validators. Use plain ASCII; you can edit the description later via the same `my.telegram.org/apps` page after the app is created.
- **App title with parentheses** is rejected by some validators. Avoid `Herald QA (2026)` — use `Herald QA 2026` instead.

Common mistakes to avoid (general):

- Don't put your **bot token** here — `my.telegram.org/apps` is for user-account apps. Bots use `@BotFather` instead.
- Don't share the `api_hash` with another project — Telegram's terms say one app = one purpose; sharing risks a rate-limit ban on both projects.
- Don't try to create more than 1 app per account in rapid succession — Telegram throttles app creation aggressively. Wait at least 1 hour between attempts if you need a second app.

5. Step 2 — Choose which phone / Telegram account to use

`HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE` must be a **real Telegram user account** (not a bot). The account will appear as the "sender" of every test-driver message in your group chat -4946584787.

⚠ Important — check existing apps FIRST. Per Telegram's official doc: each phone number is permanently bound to AT MOST ONE `app_id`. If your candidate phone already has an app at `my.telegram.org/apps` from any prior project, you **MUST** reuse that existing app — Telegram will not let you create a second one for the same phone. To check:

1. Log in at <https://my.telegram.org/auth> with the candidate phone.
2. Navigate to <https://my.telegram.org/apps>.
3. If a row already exists (e.g. "App configuration" with a `App api_id` value visible), **that IS your existing app — reuse it.** Copy the `App api_id`. For the `App api_hash`, click "edit" / "details" if visible — most Telegram form versions let you retrieve the existing hash; if not, you cannot regenerate it (revocation invalidates any active session). Use what you can recover; if truly lost, this phone is unusable for new automation and you must pick a different phone.

4. If no row exists, proceed to Step 1 to create a fresh one.

Two valid options for which phone to use:

Option	Pros	Cons	When to pick
(a) Your personal Telegram account	Fastest setup — no new SIM, no new login. The account already has trust history with Telegram (reduces anti-abuse-system suspicion). Clean separation — purpose-built account isolated from your personal Telegram. Even if the QA account gets banned, your personal account is unaffected.	Test messages appear "from you" in the QA chat. If a bug sends unintended messages, they appear from your real account. The account becomes "under observation" once you start using the userbot — minor risk of incorrect ban (recoverable via recover@telegram.org). Requires a physical SIM or eSIM and ~\$10-20/month.	Recommended for first cycle. Get Wave 8 Track B proven working, then optionally migrate to (b).
(b) Dedicated QA SIM (or eSIM)		Brand-new accounts have ZERO trust history with Telegram → much higher ban risk in the first 30 days. Must email recover@telegram.org BEFORE first login to declare the userbot purpose.	Production CI, only after you've validated the harness works with option (a) AND have notified recover@telegram.org .

~~(c) VoIP / Google Voice / Twilio / TextNow ~~ — **REMOVED**. Earlier drafts of this guide listed VoIP as an option. Telegram's anti-abuse system flags VoIP/virtual numbers aggressively and frequently bans them with USER_DEACTIVATED (no appeal). **Do not use VoIP** under any circumstances for this harness.

Session file portability: the session file persists per phone; you can later migrate from (a) to (b) by changing HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE + the session file path, no test rewrites needed.

6. Step 3 — Add the QA account to the chat

The QA user account (HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE) **MUST** be a **member of** HERALD_TGRAM_CHAT_ID (the group -4946584787 — "ATMOSphere Development"). Otherwise its messages won't reach the bot's `getUpdates` poller.

- **If using option (a) — your personal account** and you're already in that group:  **Done. Skip this step.**
- **If using options (b) or (c) — a new account:**
 1. From an existing member's Telegram (e.g. your personal account):
 - Open the "ATMOSphere Development" group.
 - Tap the group name → **Add Members** → search for the QA account's phone or username → add.
 2. **OR:** generate a group invite link, send it to the QA account, and have it join.
 3. **Verify membership** by logging into Telegram as the QA account and confirming the group is visible in its chat list.

7. Step 4 — Add the variables to .env

Open .env in your normal editor (NOT through chat — never paste secret values into chat). Append to the existing file:

```
# §11.4.98 MTPROTO user-account harness (Wave 8 Track B)
HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_ID=12345678
HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_HASH=0123456789abcdef0123456789abcdef
HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE=+12025551234
HERALD_MTPROTO_PASSWORD=
```

Substitute the values you collected:

- HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_ID — from Step 1.8 (small integer)
- HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_HASH — from Step 1.8 (32-char hex)
- HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE — from Step 2 (the QA user account's phone in E.164)
- HERALD_MTPROTO_PASSWORD — only if the account in HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE has 2FA enabled; otherwise leave the value blank (Telegram will not prompt for it)

Save the file. The .env file is git-ignored — your credentials will NOT be committed.

8. Step 5 — Verify + reply "done"

Optional pre-flight check you can run yourself (validates the api_id + api_hash without exposing them):

```
set -a; source .env; set +a
echo "APP_ID: $([ -n "$HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_ID" ] && echo PRESENT
|| echo MISSING)"
echo "APP_HASH: $([ ${#HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_HASH} -eq 32 ] && echo
OK_LENGTH || echo WRONG_LENGTH)"
echo "PHONE: $([ -n "$HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE" ] && echo PRESENT ||
echo MISSING)"
echo "PASSWORD: $([ -n "$HERALD_MTPROTO_PASSWORD" ] && echo
PRESENT_2FA || echo BLANK_NO_2FA)"
```

Expected output:

```
APP_ID: PRESENT
APP_HASH: OK_LENGTH
PHONE: PRESENT
PASSWORD: PRESENT_2FA    # or BLANK_NO_2FA
```

If all four lines are correct, **reply "done"** in chat (a single word; do NOT paste any credential values).

9. What happens next (after you reply "done")

Conductor sequence (fully automated except where noted):

1. **Audit** `.env` — presence checks only; no values echoed; verifies `api_hash` length and phone format.
2. **Vendor** `github.com/gotd/td` as a Git submodule under `submodules/gotd-td/` per Herald's vendoring convention.
3. **Scaffold** `qaherald/internal/mtproto/`:
 - `mtproto.go` — Client interface (`Connect`, `SendMessage`, `WaitForReply`, `Close`)
 - `session.go` — persistent session file management (`~/ .config/herald/mtproto.session`)
 - `errors.go` — sanitizer wrapping all error paths so `api_hash`, session bytes, and 2FA password text never appear in committed logs (HRD-133 parity)
 - Hermetic tests with mocked Telegram MTProto endpoint
4. `qaherald mtproto login` — Cobra subcommand for the one-time interactive bootstrap:
 - Connects to Telegram MTProto with your `app_id` + `app_hash`.
 - Telegram sends a login code to `HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE`'s Telegram app.
 - CLI prompts: **"Enter code Telegram sent to :"** — you type the 5-6 digit code shown in your Telegram app.
 - If 2FA: prompts **"Enter cloud password:"** — you type your `HERALD_MTPROTO_PASSWORD` (or it's read from `env`).
 - On success: writes `~/ .config/herald/mtproto.session` (`chmod 600`) + prints `"MTProto session active for @<username> (user_id=<id>)"`.
 - This is the §11.4.98(B) permitted one-time exception — configuration, not test driving. All subsequent runs are fully autonomous.
5. **Rewrite the 3 NON-COMPLIANT tests**:
 - `TestSubscribe_LiveBotAPI` → `TestSubscribe_LiveMTProto`
 - `tests/test_wave6_live_loop.sh` → `tests/test_wave6_live_mtproto.sh`
 - Wave 6.5 lifecycle scenarios → MTProto-driven equivalents
6. **Verify** - `count=3` **deterministic PASS** per §11.4.98 rule (4) — every test must PASS 3 consecutive automated invocations with self-cleaning state.
7. **Capture evidence** under `docs/qa/HRD-LIVE-MTPROTO-<TS>/` with sanitizer audit (`token-shape` + `api_hash-shape` regex → 0 matches required).
8. **Flip the SKIP-with-reason invariants** in `scripts/e2e_bluff_hunt.sh` to PASS (E17 / E18 / E34 / E63-E70 / E71-E80).
9. **Commit + push 4 mirrors** + close the §11.4.98 audit (Task #223) — release-gate item.

Estimated wall-clock time from "done" reply to fully-COMPLIANT closed-loop: ~2-4 hours depending on Telegram code-delivery latency and number of test cycles. The login is ~1-minute interactive; everything else is autonomous.

10. Security notes (composes with §11.4.10)

1. **Never commit** `HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_HASH` or the session file to git. Both are sufficient to impersonate the QA account. `.env` and `~/ .config/herald/mtproto.session` MUST stay out of any tracked path.

2. **Never share the `api_hash` with another project.** Each project gets its own `my.telegram.org` app per Telegram's terms; sharing risks rate-limit bans across both.
 3. **Treat the session file like an SSH private key.** `chmod 600`, owned by the running user, never world-readable.
 4. **Rotate the `api_hash` + invalidate the session** if leaked: `my.telegram.org/apps` → revoke + recreate; then `rm ~/.config/herald/mtproto.session` and re-login.
 5. **HRD-133 sanitizer applies to MTPROTO errors too** — the harness will `sanitizeMTPROTOError()` wrap every error path. Any test transcript or log committed to `docs/qa/` is post-sanitization; the `api_hash`, session bytes, and 2FA password text NEVER appear in any committed artefact.
 6. **The session file is bound to your `HERALD_MTPROTO_PHONE`.** Moving it to another machine for the same account is fine (`chmod 600` it on the target). DO NOT use the same session file for two simultaneously-running test campaigns — Telegram detects parallel sessions and may invalidate one.
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11. Troubleshooting

AUTH_KEY_UNREGISTERED on first run: The session file from a previous account is present and stale. Run `rm ~/.config/herald/mtproto.session` and re-run `qa herald mtproto login`.

PHONE_CODE_INVALID: The login code was entered wrong or expired (codes valid ~5 minutes). Re-run; Telegram sends a fresh one.

SESSION_PASSWORD_NEEDED: The QA account has 2FA enabled. Add `HERALD_MTPROTO_PASSWORD=<your cloud password>` to `.env` and re-run. The cloud password is what Telegram asks you for when you reinstall the app — set under Settings → Privacy & Security → Two-Step Verification.

FLOOD_WAIT_<N>: Telegram is rate-limiting login attempts on this phone (often after multiple recent attempts). Wait <N> seconds (sometimes 30s, sometimes hours during aggressive throttling). Avoid hammering re-login attempts.

PHONE_NUMBER_INVALID: Wrong E.164 format. Use `+<country code><number>` with NO spaces or dashes. Examples:

- US: `+12025551234`
- UK: `+447911123456`
- Serbia: `+381601234567`
- Germany: `+4915123456789`

USER_DEACTIVATED: Telegram has deactivated the QA account (often happens to VoIP / suspicious-pattern accounts). Try option (b) — dedicated SIM. There is no appeal process for deactivated accounts in most cases.

The harness sends messages but `@atmosphere_worker_bot`'s poller doesn't see them: Confirm the QA account is a member of `HERALD_TGRAM_CHAT_ID`. The privacy boundary that blocks bot-to-bot ALSO blocks "user-not-in-chat → bot". Add the QA account to the group (Step 3 above).

`api_id` is reported invalid even though it's the right value: Make sure you're using the integer (no quotes, no leading zeros). Example correct: `HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_ID=12345678`. Example wrong:

HERALD_MTPROTO_APP_ID="12345678" (don't quote; .env is sourced by shell which strips quotes inconsistently).

You created the app under your personal account but want to drive QA from a different account: The api_id + api_hash are bound to the my.telegram.org account that created them BUT can be used to log in as ANY Telegram user. So this is fine — the api_id/api_hash identify the *application*, the phone identifies the *user driving it*. You can re-use one app's credentials to log in many users.

You can't access my.telegram.org because Telegram requires phone confirmation but you're in a country where Telegram is blocked: Use a VPN to a country where Telegram is reachable (e.g. EU / US) for the initial app creation. Once you have the api_id + api_hash, they work from anywhere (the MTPROTO client connects to Telegram's IPs which may need their own VPN-around routing — but app creation is the bottleneck).

12. Cross-references

- **HelixConstitution §11.4.98** — <parent>/constitution/Constitution.md, commit 6828ff2 (canonical authority for the full-automation mandate).
- **Herald §108.m** — docs/guides/HERALD_CONSTITUTION.md r8 (project-binding restatement).
- **Herald restatements** — CLAUDE.md r14, AGENTS.md r10, QWEN.md (all carry literal anchor 11.4.98).
- **OPERATOR_CREDENTIALS.md** — docs/guides/OPERATOR_CREDENTIALS.md §"MTPROTO user-account harness" (the full reference; this blocker doc is the operator-actionable subset).
- **Live evidence audit** — docs/qa/HRD-LIVE-20260528T082128Z/README.md (the 2026-05-28 honest classification that surfaced the manual-dependency NON-COMPLIANT status).
- **Empirical bot-to-bot wall test** — docs/qa/HRD-LIVE-20260528T082128Z/04_wave6_closed_loop/pherald_journal/transcript.jsonl + the embedded chat log showing 0-update reception.
- **Telegram's MTPROTO docs** — https://core.telegram.org/api/obtaining_api_id (the official Telegram doc for the my.telegram.org app-creation flow).
- **gotd/td Go library** — <https://github.com/gotd/td> (the MTPROTO client Herald will vendor).
- **Operator memory telegram_bot_to_bot_wall** — the prior research note that called the MTPROTO requirement before this 2026-05-28 cycle empirically confirmed it.

Status tracking

Track	Status	Reference
§11.4.98 propagation (HelixConstitution + Herald)	✅ DONE	HelixConstitution 6828ff2, Herald bb f03c8
.env.example expansion + canonical docs guide	✅ DONE	Herald 35fc10c
This blocker document + sibling exports	🕒 in flight	Herald (this commit)
Operator provides MTPROTO credentials	🕒 AWAITING YOU	Reply "done" when .env is populated

Track	Status	Reference
Vendor gotd/td + scaffold qaherald/ internal/mtproto/	 blocked-on- creds	Wave 8 Track B (Task #221)
qaherald mtproto login (one-time interactive bootstrap)	 blocked-on- creds	Wave 8 Track B
Rewrite 3 NON-COMPLIANT tests to MTPROTO-driven	 blocked-on- creds	Wave 8 Track B
§11.4.98 audit of all existing tests	 pending	Task #223

You can open this document and begin Step 1 now. Reply "done" when .env is populated.